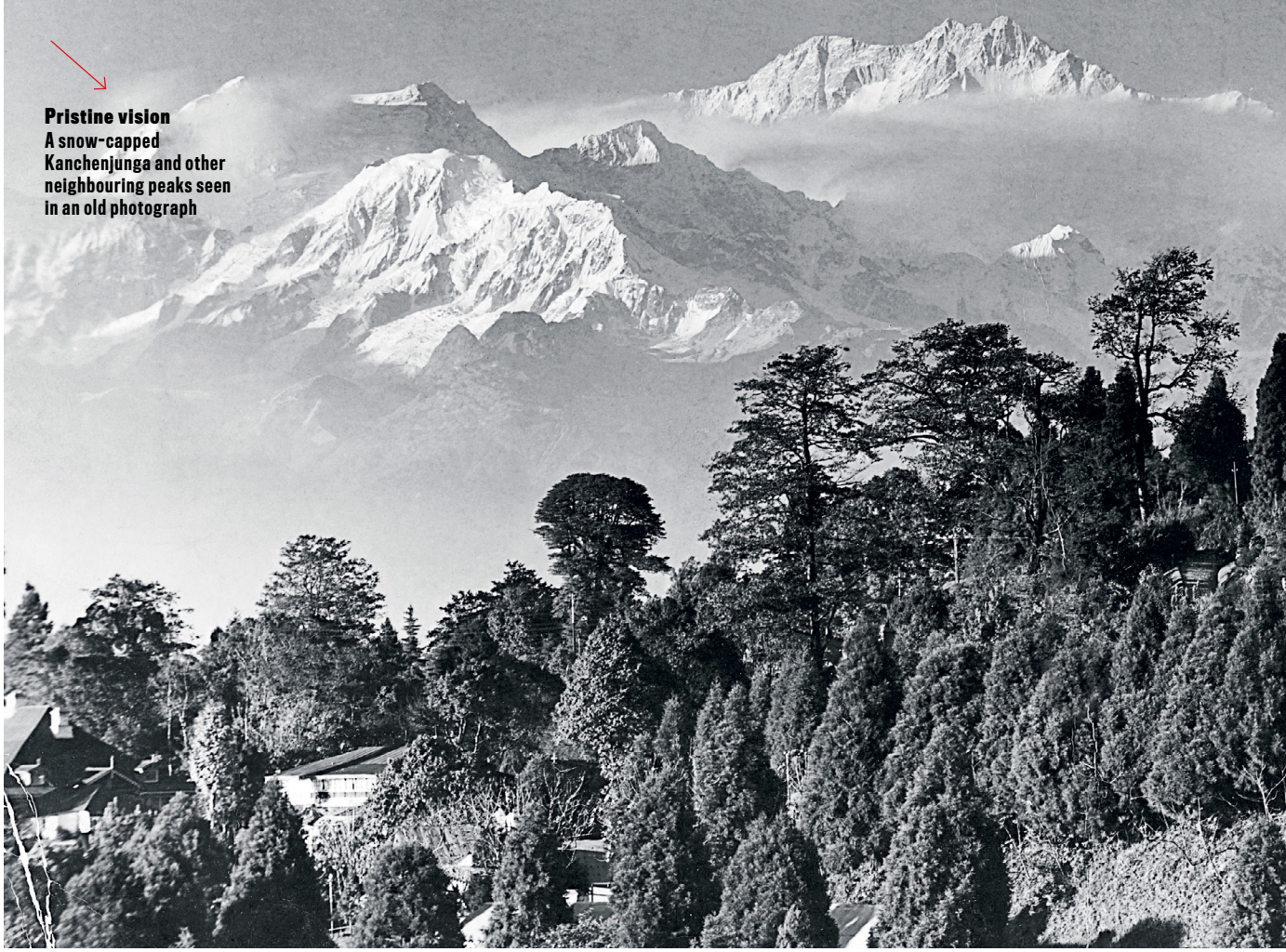


Pristine vision
A snow-capped Kanchenjunga and other neighbouring peaks seen in an old photograph

Photographs by GETTY IMAGES

FREEDOM@75 THE ENVIRONMENT
FORESTS

A NEW LEAF

They may be protected, but the twin pressures of population and development are taking a toll on forests

By Rahul Noronha

Forests—teeming with wildlife and precious, diverse flora—are the lungs of the nation and vital for ecological balance. But this wisdom has been a long time coming. From being regarded as a revenue earner and a resource to be exploited in colonial times and in the years immediately after Independence, the last several decades have at last witnessed a paradigm shift in the way forests are managed.



Nature violated
Logs from chopped-down trees in a deforested area